

Limestone delivery fosters hobby

The delivery of limestone for the family driveway did more for Jane Freese than just provide a road surface--it paved the way for involvement in a new hobby--fossil collecting.

"I noticed that this limestone contained some interesting fossils and I have been hooked on collecting fossils every since--for the past 10 years," stated Jane.

The fossil hound explained that "Iowa is rich in fossils in

fact, it is one of the best states for collectors. I had a fossil 'goldmine' right in my back yard and didn't even realize it until that one day. Many of my fossils have come from a limestone quarry located just three miles from our family farm."

"Millions of years ago Iowa was covered with shallow seas and as these seas dried animals were caught in the earth and rocks and thus this is the reason the state is a fossil

collector's paradise." Jane continued, "the Bible of fossil collecting was written by Carol and Mildred Fenton, who did much of the research for their book at Rockford, Iowa. People from all over the world come to Rockford, Nora Springs and Pella, Iowa to hunt for and study fossils."

Jane explained that most of the fossils found in Iowa are from the Paleozoic era during the Mississippian and Devon-

continued on page 2

FOSSIL COLLECTION

continued from page 1

ian period in history or in layman's terms, 200 to 500 million years ago before the age of the dinosaur.

Jane's fossil hobby has branched out as she also collects books and source material which helps in the identification of the fossils. She also has added some pieces of petrified wood to her fossil collection.

The fossil hound's collection includes a Trilobite, which is one of the first fossils to display a bodily form. This forebearer of the crab and lobster, has been extinct for 200 million years. Jane also proudly displays a Gastrolith Dinosaur gizzard stone. It seems that dinosaurs didn't have gizzards but they ate rocks to help their digestion and thus the name gizzard stone.

The fossil collection has served as a means for Jane to meet some interesting people as most fossil collectors participate in 'fossil swapping'. Jane explains, "a rock swap is a place where collectors meet, search for fossils and trade their treasures." In addition, Jane explains that she has swapped fossils by mail with people from Canada and Oregon.

Jane was a charter member of the Black Hawk Gem and Mineral Society but she is no longer active in this organization. "I was the only person from the Dumont area who was a member of this organization and so I had to drive by myself to the meetings. One time I came home in a blinding blizzard and as I was struggling through the storm I found myself thinking that it was crazy to be risking my life just for a hobby."

Jane's hobby has also benefited the community as she has taken Dumont school children and church groups on fossil hunts.



Fossils, Fossils everywhere. Jane Freese displays one of her favorite fossils from her collection.